



Last dance: The likes of Mitchell Starc, Nathan Lyon and Steve Smith are pushing towards the wrong side of the thirties, lending this upcoming series even more of a context. GETTY IMAGES

continue to be the pillars of the batting unit. David Warner's retirement led to a mini-scramble at the top, which has since been resolved with 25-year-old Nathan McSweeney set to make his debut.

However, the Australian batters had an underwhelming series in New Zealand earlier this year, where all-rounder Cameron Green, who is

ruled out of the BGT due to injury, was the top-scorer. The Indian quicks will thus have an opportunity to prey on the lingering effects of that blip.

India will take a lot of confidence from bowling linchpin Jasprit Bumrah's exploits Down Under.

Over the last two BGT series in Australia, only Australian skipper Pat Cummins (35 in eight matches) has taken more wickets than Bumrah (32 in seven).

The Indian pacer also has the best bowling average (21.25) across the two series, among bowlers to have taken more than five wickets.

But it doesn't work in India's

favour that its expectations with the ball have come down to the individualistic genius of Bumrah.

In the absence of the still recovering-from-injury Mohammed Shami, Bumrah has been shouldering the Indian pace bowling duties almost singlehandedly. In 2024, Bumrah has 41 wickets in nine Tests, while the next-best Indian pacer, Mohammed Siraj, tallied just 19 from the same number of matches.

Even though Akash Deep impressed in patches against England and New Zealand, the heat of the Australian challenge might be a little too much for the Bengal pacer.

This dire situation has forced the Indian management to fast-track Harshit Rana into the Test setup. The 22-year-old's hit-the-deck style could work out on the bouncy tracks of Australia. But betting on a bowler who has played just 10 First-Class games in a high-intensity series like

India and Australia series results in current WTC cycle

India	Australia
Beat West Indies 1-0 (Away)	Drew with England 2-2 (Away)
Drew with South Africa 1-1 (Away)	Beat Pakistan 3-0 (Home)
Beat England 4-1 (Home)	Drew with West Indies 1-1 (Home)
Beat Bangladesh 2-0 (Home)	Beat New Zealand 2-0 (Away)
Lost to New Zealand 0-3 (Home)	